

film reviews Epic Waste

DASAVATHARAM

Director: K.S. Ravikumar

Starring: Kamal Haasan, Asin, Mallika Sherawat and Jayaprada

Dasavatharam is an epic film in more ways than one. To begin with, the epic-like narrative, which is probably one of the few good things in the film. Like the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*, the plot moves seamlessly into sub plots and smaller stories, digressing into many areas with characters, stories and interludes on their own, always interconnecting, to come back together to form one complete whole.

What the narrative does, the film fails to do—for it is a one-man show, created for the sole purpose of showcasing technical brilliance and the endless possibilities in cinema today. And, of course, to showcase the epic talent of



ONE-MAN SHOW: A still from the movie *Dasavatharam*

Kamal Haasan.

Where it fails is that it tries too hard. The fact that Kamal is an awesome performer is a given, but this film insists on hammering the fact again and again into the audience with not one but 10 roles, all played out by him. These characters include George Bush, a Japanese warrior, and an American assassin.

Kamal, needless to say, is omnipotent and manifests himself in almost every frame in some avatar or the other. If the latest techniques in make-up and special

effects were to be showcased, then *Dasavatharam* is a perfect vehicle but as a film, it simply fails to move beyond the obvious. From 12th century AD hero Rangarajan Nambi to Govind, the Indian scientist based in the US, the plot veers from tyrant kings to the tsunami in 2004 with Mallika Sherawat kicking up a storm with a pole dance for good measure. A line from the audience sums up the film experience best. "I think it wasn't really Mallika Sherawat, it was actually Kamal Haasan."

by Nirmala Ravindran

recommendations Colourful Delight

MUMBAI Gallery

Pradarshak's Harvest—A Glimpse into the Golden Crop, is a show that features artists who began their creative journey with the gallery and have since then scaled great heights. Featuring nine artists, Milburn Cheria, Ranjit Kurmi, Eknath Giram, Aniket



A work on display

Khupse and Nilesch Pawar among others, the exhibition celebrates the "sustained maturity" in the works of each of them. While Giram uses Krishna as his central theme to display an atypical portrait of the deity, Kurmi's semi-abstract paintings bear a touch of the self in relation to socio-cultural environment. On till June 30.

by Swati Mathur

No One Goes First

MERE BAAP PEHLE AAP

Director: Priyadarshan

Starring: Akshaye Khanna, Paresh Rawal

It's no surprise that Priyadarshan's film is a remake of a Malayalam hit, *Istham*. It's also no surprise that a blooming southern superstar has been reduced by Bollywood to a wilting wallflower. The wondrous Shobhana, who fairly scorches the screen in Malayalam cinema, plays the antiseptic love interest of Paresh Rawal in this



PARTLY FUNNY: Rawal and Khanna in *Mere Baap Pehle Aap*

situational comedy which is funny in such few parts that it would have been better off as a drama about ageing romance. Khanna and Rawal try hard to feel mutual love (they play a doting father-devoted son) but the

time has long gone when Khanna could play cute and Rawal could smoulder. As for supposed bright young thing Genelia D'Souza, there is such a thing as too much perkiness. It's called bad acting. by Kaveer Banzal

DELHI Swati Subodh

Siddhartha presents a kathak dance recital titled Rang—Colours of Devotion, at the India International Centre on June 29. In this production by Aadyantara, various facets of devotion as conceived and penned by poets like Kalidas, Amir Khusrau and Meera, spanning different eras, will be depicted. Using the grammar of kathak, this presentation depicts the colours of devotion in a language which emerges out of an amalgamation of the poets' imagination and the artists' own interpretation.